World Governance Indicators Dataset

Overview

Attribute	Value
Source	World Bank Worldwide Governance Indicators (WGI)
URL	https://info.worldbank.org/governance/wgi/
Samples	5,045 country-year observations
Features	6 governance indicators
Time Period	1996–2023
Countries	214 unique
Missing Values	Some country-year combinations may have missing indicators

Description

The Worldwide Governance Indicators (WGI) report aggregate and individual governance indicators for over 200 countries and territories since 1996. The indicators are based on hundreds of underlying variables from a wide variety of existing data sources, capturing governance perceptions from survey respondents, NGOs, commercial businesses, and public sector organizations worldwide.

This dataset contains panel data (repeated observations of the same countries over time), with each row representing one country in one year.

Variables

Identification Variables

Variable	Description
country	Country name
country_code	ISO 3-letter country code
year	Year of observation (1996–2023)

Governance Indicators

All six indicators are continuous scores, standardized to approximately mean 0 and standard deviation 1. Higher values indicate better governance.

Variable	Description	Approximate Range
control_corruption	Perceptions of the extent to which public power is exercised for private gain, including both petty and grand forms of corruption, as well as "capture" of the state by elites and private interests	-2.5 to +2.5

Variable	Description	Approximate Range
govt_effectiveness	Perceptions of the quality of public services, the quality of the civil service and the degree of its independence from political pressures, the quality of policy formulation and implementation, and the credibility of the government's commitment to such policies	-2.5 to +2.5
political_stability	Perceptions of the likelihood of political instability and/or politically-motivated violence, including terrorism	-2.5 to +2.5
regulatory_quality	Perceptions of the ability of the government to formulate and implement sound policies and regulations that permit and promote private sector development	-2.5 to +2.5
rule_of_law	Perceptions of the extent to which agents have confidence in and abide by the rules of society, and in particular the quality of contract enforcement, property rights, the police, and the courts, as well as the likelihood of crime and violence	-2.5 to +2.5
voice_accountability	Perceptions of the extent to which a country's citizens are able to participate in selecting their government, as well as freedom of expression, freedom of association, and a free media	-2.5 to +2.5

Interpretation of Scores

- Higher values indicate stronger governance
- Scores are centered (approximately mean 0) and scaled (approximately standard deviation 1)
- The range is approximately -2.5 (weakest governance) to +2.5 (strongest governance)
- Units represent standard deviations from the cross-country mean

Panel Structure

Each country appears in multiple years (up to 28 observations per country, from 1996 to 2023). This means the 5,045 observations are not all independent — the same country's governance scores in adjacent years will be related. Consider this structure when conducting your analysis.

Data Access

Loading from Local CSV (Recommended)

The dataset is provided as `governance_data.csv` in this folder.

Python:

```python
import pandas as pd

df = pd.read_csv('governance_data.csv')
gov_cols = ['control_corruption', 'govt_effectiveness', 'political_stability',
            'regulatory_quality', 'rule_of_law', 'voice_accountability']
X = df[gov_cols]

print(f"Observations: {len(df)}")
print(f"Countries: {df['country'].nunique()}")
print(f"Year range: {df['year'].min()}-{df['year'].max()}")
```

R:

```r
df <- read.csv('governance_data.csv')
gov_cols <- c('control_corruption', 'govt_effectiveness', 'political_stability',
              'regulatory_quality', 'rule_of_law', 'voice_accountability')
X <- df[, gov_cols]

cat("Observations:", nrow(df), "\n")
cat("Countries:", length(unique(df$country)), "\n")
cat("Year range:", min(df$year), "-", max(df$year), "\n")
```

Julia:

```julia
using CSV, DataFrames

df = CSV.read("governance_data.csv", DataFrame)
gov_cols = [:control_corruption, :govt_effectiveness, :political_stability,
            :regulatory_quality, :rule_of_law, :voice_accountability]
X = select(df, gov_cols)

println("Observations: $(nrow(df))")
println("Countries: $(length(unique(df.country)))")
println("Year range: $(minimum(df.year))-$(maximum(df.year))")
```

Official Source

World Bank Worldwide Governance Indicators: https://info.worldbank.org/governance/wgi/

Citation

Kaufmann, Daniel, Aart Kraay and Massimo Mastruzzi (2010). "The Worldwide Governance Indicators: Methodology and Analytical Issues". *World Bank Policy Research Working Paper No. 5430.*

BibTeX:

```bibtex
@techreport{kaufmann2010wgi,
  title={The Worldwide Governance Indicators: Methodology and Analytical Issues},
  author={Kaufmann, Daniel and Kraay, Aart and Mastruzzi, Massimo},
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